

Ill-matched Partners

3 Many familiar lines of prose and poetry owe their place in Bartlett's to their balanced cadences. "Marriage has many pains," says Samuel Johnson, "but celibacy has no pleasures." "The Puritan hated bear-baiting," Macauley explains, "not because it gave pain to the bear, but because it gave pleasure to the spectators." Deprived of their parallel structure, some famous quotations lose their punch:

I come for the purpose of burying Caesar, not to praise him.

Was this the face that launched a thousand ships and was responsible for the burning of Ilium's topless towers?

. . . brought forth on this continent a new nation that had its conception in liberty and was dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal.

Many are called, but God doesn't choose more than a few.

. . . that all men . . . have certain unalienable rights: to life, liberty, and to pursue happiness.

The originals mangled here echo insistently enough to demonstrate their superiority. And though you need not strive for the perfect symmetry of, say, the Sermon on the Mount (a style best reserved for special occasions), parallel constructions have an important role in all writing. Appropriately matched components can make the difference between a sentence that runs smoothly and one that jerks along in fits and starts.

Most sentences meet the test of parallel structure when the elements presented in series or pairs belong to the same grammatical category, that is, when all are adjectives, nouns, active verbs, infinitives, phrases, or clauses. Just as you can't add apples and oranges, at least not without reducing them to pieces of fruit, you can't yoke disparate parts of speech or different types of constructions and expect them to function together efficiently. To write *He is determined, a fighter, and has a quick mind* or *We need employees with specific skills and who can work as a team* is like harnessing a horse, a goat, and a camel to a troika or designing a chair with a rocker on one side and a pair of legs on the other.

To some extent parallel constructions are idiomatic. Children chant, or used to, *Doctor, lawyer, merchant, chief*; romantic heroes are *tall, dark, and handsome*; Pal Joey's ladylove is *bewitched, bothered, and bewildered*; Caesar said, *I came, I saw, I conquered*; and Lincoln spoke of a government *of the people, by the people, and for the people*. More often than not, parallel structure comes naturally to us. We might describe the typical Swede as fair, blond, and blue-eyed or as having fair skin, blond hair, and blue eyes; we would be unlikely to say that the stereotype is fair, a blond, and has blue eyes. Such imbalances make us uneasy. You don't have to know the rules of rhetoric to sense that something is wrong with *We are told to live our own lives and that we should not interfere with how others behave*, but an experienced editor would immediately recognize that the infinitive phrase and the *that* clause make a lopsided pair. To right the balance, you could substitute *not to interfere* for *that we should not interfere*, and perhaps someone arrived at that point before coming up with the inspired *to live and let live*. For while we're naturally attracted to parallel pairs and series, they don't always come readily to mind. As Wilson Follett observes, felicitous writing "seems inevitable, but if we could contemplate the doing of it from a little in advance of the fact, we should see nothing marked out as foreordained, but rather a labyrinth of ways to go wrong."

UNBALANCED PAIRS AND SERIES

You can detect most errors in parallel structure by routinely checking the words or word groups you join by *and* and *or* and making sure that they match. In other words, the elements linked as compound subjects, objects, verbs, and modifiers should have the same grammatical form. When they don't, you can either bring them into line or change the structure to eliminate the need for parallelism.

Since faults in parallel structure are easy to spot, their abundance in print is somewhat surprising. But deadlines often leave little time for polishing, and revisions can be tricky. When you find an imbalance, first try to put the coordinate items in the same form, converting an adjective and a noun, say, to two adjectives or two nouns. Sometimes, though, the right terms prove elusive, and forcing two elements into the same structure may make the sentence wordy or stilted. The serial items are not parallel in *The new clerk is intelligent, conscientious, and wants to change the system*, but . . . *is intelligent, conscientious, and desirous of changing the system* isn't much of an improvement. While the form of the series is flawless, the artificial wording calls attention to itself.

Serial or paired items that are hard to balance may not belong together; they may resist alignment because they are not logically similar. The solution then is to uncouple the combination, to subordinate one component to the others instead of making them all coordinate: *The new clerk, who is intelligent and conscientious, wants to change the system*.

The following examples represent some of the most common types of mismatches, and the alternatives suggest possible revisions:

The proposed transmission line is ugly, unsafe, and an environmental danger.

- . . . ugly, unsafe, and hazardous to the environment.

The process is slow, prone to politics, and robs all concerned of direct responsibility.

- . . . slow and prone to politics, robbing all concerned of direct responsibility.

The applicants were all college graduates, of similar socioeconomic background, and interested in business careers.

- . . . all college-educated, similar in socioeconomic background, and interested in business careers.

Your cover letter should include information about your present employment and why you want to change jobs.

- . . . should include information about your present employment and explain why you want to change jobs.

The problem is on the minds of millions of Americans, young and old and in all parts of the country, not only in Louisiana.

- . . . on the minds of millions of young and old Americans in all parts of the country, not only in Louisiana.

The mismatched pairs and series in the above examples involve such combinations as adjective and noun, adjective and verb, noun

and prepositional phrase, and noun and clause. Some imbalances are less pronounced than these and are not even universally regarded as flaws. Still, they leave room for improvement. If, for instance, you've coordinated an active verb with a passive or linking one, consider substituting two active verbs or recasting the sentence to avoid the ill-matched compound. For example:

Farm failures contributed to the 1917 revolution and were one of the reasons for Khrushchev's ouster in 1964.

- Farm failures contributed to the 1917 revolution and to Khrushchev's ouster in 1964.

He has worked for the bank for many years, is knowledgeable about nearly all areas of banking, and will be an excellent addition to top management.

- Employed by the bank for many years and knowledgeable about nearly all areas of banking, he will be an excellent addition to top management.

She ranks as the country's top railroad analyst and is often consulted by financial writers and stockbrokers.

- As the country's top railroad analyst, she is often consulted by financial writers and stockbrokers.

Combinations of nouns and gerunds can also be jarring, though less so than those involving different parts of speech. Since a gerund is the *ing* verb form used as a noun, it might seem a fit associate for a purebred noun, but when its verbal side is insistent, the two don't work well together. Apparently, however, not all experts would agree. One author, in analyzing various sorts of writing errors, makes no apology for this sentence:

When people have to write from a point of view not their own, they . . . betray this by hedging, blustering, an uneasy choice of words, and syntactical looseness.

In this context the gerunds suggest people doing something—hedging and blustering—and this active element is absent from the noun phrases in the series. But the items do not go gently into parallel structure:

. . . by hedging, blustering, misusing words, and lapsing into syntactical looseness.

Or:

. . . by an uneasy choice of words, syntactical looseness, and a tendency to hedge and bluster.

The difficulty in making the terms grammatically compatible suggests that they are not logically equivalent, and you might decide to restructure the sentence. Here's one possibility:

When people write from a point of view not their own, they hedge and bluster, betraying uneasiness in their choice of words and their loose syntax.

In the next example one conventional noun intrudes in a series of gerunds:

The technical reforms needed to protect Social Security include curtailing preferential federal pensions, bringing federal employees into the system, raising the retirement age to sixty-eight, modification of the indexing policy, and increasing military careers to thirty-three years.

It's hard to understand how anyone could use *modification of* instead of *modifying* in that sentence. Similarly mystifying is the choice of *the construction of* over *constructing* in this one:

The plan entailed razing the entire business district—thirty-four buildings dating from the nineteenth century—and the construction of a modern shopping plaza.

In some series, however, gerunds and conventional nouns mingle without friction, either because the grouping is loose enough not to require precise parallelism or because the verbal qualities of the gerunds do not surface. Whatever the explanation, you can usually tell instinctively whether or not a gerund is out of place in a group of straight nouns. In the earlier examples the change in form brings you up short, but in the following series you hardly notice it:

Among the many aspects of credit examined are credit scoring, debt burden, the cash analysis system used by banks, the difference between charge and credit cards, debt servicing, credit ratings for women, denial of credit profiles, and the personal judgment factor.

An accomplished writer may occasionally use an unbalanced pair or series for a specific reason—perhaps to imitate a style of speech or to achieve a comic effect. Few would quarrel with Lorenz Hart's "I'm wild again, beguiled again, a simpering, whimpering child again" or with the riddle that asks "What's big and red and eats rocks?" (Answer: "A big red rock eater.") But if you set aside the rules of parallelism, know what you're doing and why. Unintentional violations reflect laziness or ignorance.

PARALLELISM AND CORRELATIVE CONJUNCTIONS

Whatever leeway you allow yourself in balancing coordinate elements in general, you should enforce a rigid parallelism on those

connected by the so-called correlative conjunctions—principally, *either . . . or*, *neither . . . nor*, *both . . . and*, and *not only* (or an equivalent like *not just*, *not simply*, or *not merely*) . . . *but also* (or *but if* what follows seems to intensify rather than to supplement). These double connectives emphasize the correspondence between the word groups they introduce, and it offends logic not to make the companion pieces grammatically equivalent. The first one makes readers anticipate a mate, and it's unsettling for those expecting a second shoe to drop to hear instead the thud of a chair or the shattering of a teacup.

When you're roughing out a first draft, the conjunctions may not fall where they belong (*I not only sent a copy to my supervisor but also to the head of the division*), but be sure to put them right when you revise (*I sent a copy not only to my supervisor but also to the head of the division*). A good editor never reads over correlative conjunctions without checking what they introduce and correcting any inequities. A sentence like the next one should never have got past the newspaper's copy desk:

The officers were not only well respected professionally but they also often went hunting and fishing with their colleagues on the state police and local sheriff's department.

The following revision at least meets the technical requirements of parallel structure:

Not only were the officers well respected professionally but they had often gone hunting and fishing with their colleagues on the state police force and in the local sheriff's department.

This alternative corrects not only the improper placement of the correlative conjunctions but also the imbalance between *state police* and *local sheriff's department*; in the original the two law-enforcement agencies were linked as compound objects of *on*, but *on the . . . department* is unidiomatic. The solution to the *not only*–*but also* problem is less satisfactory, since *were respected professionally* and *had gone fishing* make an odd couple. Though each correlative now introduces a coordinate clause, the ideas are not in balance. You can get better results by changing the word order and finding a more compatible verb to pair with *respected*:

The officers' colleagues on the state police force and in the local sheriff's department not only respected the men professionally but regarded them as friends, having often gone hunting and fishing with them.

Devising an acceptable version of the last example took considerable effort, and perhaps the news item came in too late to rewrite. But many mistakes in the use of correlatives are easily fixed. Sometimes you need only transpose one of the conjunctions or add an article or

a preposition. The elements after correlative conjunctions should correspond exactly; if, for example, the first conjunction precedes a preposition that governs both elements, you should either repeat the preposition after the second conjunction or move the preposition ahead of the first conjunction. Here are some typical errors and corrections:

From the beginning this faction has been critical both of the motivation and the tactics of the new government.

- . . . has been critical of both the motivation and the tactics. . . .

The end can neither be known nor imagined.

- . . . can be neither known nor imagined.

He began to stay late at the office, either because the work was piling up or to impress his staff.

- . . . either to clear away the work that was piling up or to impress his staff.
- . . . either because his work was piling up or because he hoped to impress his staff.

These virtues are not only the heart of liberal learning but they also perform a critical social function: they constitute the glue that holds the community together.

- These virtues not only constitute the heart of liberal learning but also perform a critical social function: they serve as the glue. . . .
- These virtues are not only the heart of liberal learning but also the glue that holds the community together. (Is there any need to point out that holding the community together is a critical social function?)

The company not only dominated the town's business but also the way the residents lived and thought.

- The company dominated not only the town's business but also the way. . . .

In pointing out the dangers of nicotine, the surgeon general is not only referring to smoking cigarettes but also chewing tobacco.

- . . . surgeon general is referring not only to smoking cigarettes but also to chewing tobacco.

In highlighting the matching parts of a sentence and thus showing which elements go together, correlative conjunctions sometimes provide a useful means of avoiding ambiguity. In the last example, for instance, the misplacement of *not only* is especially awkward because it mismatches *referring* and *chewing*, suggesting that the surgeon gen-

eral was chomping on a wad of tobacco when he made his announcement. But since the correlatives—especially *not only . . . but also* and *both . . . and*—are emphatic devices, don't squander them on compound elements that don't need them. Using correlative conjunctions where a simple *and* would do is like driving in a thumbtack with a sledgehammer. For example:

I have the figures for both the first quarter and the second.

I read not only your report but also the list of recommendations you attached.

Although the correlative conjunctions must precede parallel parts of the sentence, the terms that make up these pairs do not invariably function together. Each can operate alone. In particular, you can use *not only* without necessarily going on to *but also* or *but*. *Not only* always promises more to come, but the rules of rhetoric allow alternative ways of keeping that promise:

It is not only our country that faces this problem, most Western nations have high unemployment rates.

Not only our country but also most other Western nations have high unemployment rates.

The comma after *problem* in the first of these examples shows that the sentence is not yet complete. *Not only* signals something to follow. This construction is one of the few that permit the junction of independent clauses without a stronger mark of punctuation or a coordinating conjunction.

PARALLELISM AND CLARITY

As the preceding sections emphasize, the proper management of parallel structure has a great deal to do with a pleasing writing style, and you should mix and match your sentence components as attentively as the well-dressed coordinate their outfits. The difference between a carefully assembled sentence and one just thrown together is the difference between a Neiman-Marcus mannequin and a cornfield scarecrow.

But the value of parallel structure goes beyond aesthetics. While the eighteenth-century essayists used perfectly balanced clauses primarily for rhetorical effect, the matching of parts within clauses often serves a more practical purpose. It points up the structure of the sentence, showing readers what goes with what and keeping them on

the right track. Without this sort of coordination a sentence may be not only awkward but open to misinterpretation. For example:

Emphasis is placed on explaining the company's controls and how effective those controls can be.

What two elements does the *and* connect here? Neither of the possibilities on its left, the gerund *explaining* and the noun *controls*, matches the *how* clause on the right, so that readers can't be sure which elements function together. They can guess, of course, but any structure that requires guesswork also requires revision. If *controls* is the first element in the pair, you can improve the sentence by converting the *how* clause to a modifier-noun combination:

Emphasis is placed on explaining the company's controls and their effectiveness.

But since *controls* and *their effectiveness* do not seem distinct topics, a more condensed revision might be more precise:

Emphasis is placed on explaining the effectiveness of the company's controls.

If the gerund and the clause are the compound elements, you can convert the clause to a verbal phrase:

Emphasis is placed on explaining the company's controls and on demonstrating their effectiveness.

Let's look at another example:

The article on American agriculture explains the interacting forces of technology, government policies, fluctuating demand, international politics, inflation and recession, surpluses and subsidies, land values, the real cost of borrowed capital, and how fallow fields can earn more than fertile ones.

You might think at first that the final *and* introduces the last item of the long series and that the clause should be made compatible with the other items in the series—converted, say, to *the potential of fallow fields to earn more than fertile ones*. But if you pay attention to the meaning, you can see that the original *how* clause does not belong in the list of interacting forces. Rather, it parallels *forces*, functioning as a second object of *explains*. The revision could read:

. . . explains how various forces interact to affect farming—technology, government policies . . . borrowed capital—and how fallow fields can earn more than fertile ones.

In many contexts you have to repeat a subordinating conjunction, a preposition, an article, or an auxiliary verb before each element in a

pair or series to reinforce the parallelism and prevent misalliances. For example:

Limit the candidates to those managers who can provide independently measured results or firms that can provide good recent references.

Here readers might initially see *results* and *firms* as joint objects of *can provide*. Though they would quickly reject this pairing in favor of *managers* and *firms*, a *to* before *firms* would have prevented the flicker of hesitation.

You usually don't have to repeat an article before each noun in a pair or series (*a pair* or *a series*, for example, might be called pedantic, schoolmarmish, or overrefined—the adjective depending on which usage critic you consult). Strict grammarians recommend using an indefinite article before each coordinate term when one word requires *a* and the other *an*, but this rule can also go by the board in informal contexts (*Eat an apple, peach, or pear every day; He wasn't wearing a hat or overcoat*). When articles do need repeating, we generally include them automatically. If you attend a meeting with two business acquaintances, for example, you might say you went *with a broker and a banker*. *A broker and banker* would imply a single companion who wears two hats. When you use correlative conjunctions, an article must appear with the second element if it does with the first. Though you may say *Get me a hammer and nail*, you would have to say *I don't have either a hammer or a nail* or *I have neither hammer nor nail*. Occasionally you need articles before both nouns in a pair to prevent the second one from being misread as a verb. Another *a* would be helpful, for example, in *Whenever I attend a seminar or lecture on the new technology I become depressed*.

Duplicate whatever words help to establish the relation between compound elements. You needn't repeat articles and prepositions that don't contribute to clarity, but you shouldn't omit those that provide guidance. Without pointers to the contrary, readers assume that an *and* or *or* connects the word group on its left to the corresponding one on its right. A second *about* would serve no purpose, for example, in *I talked about my predecessor and his influence on our policy*, where *and* obviously links the two objects of the preposition. The sentence permits no other interpretation. But in *I talked about my predecessor's influence on our policy and the steps I plan to take*, you need another *about* after *and* to keep readers from seeing *policy* and *steps* as joint objects of *on*. Since *and* does not connect the terms adjacent to it, you have to take precautions against misreading.

Be sure to treat all items in a series consistently. Don't repeat a preposition or a conjunction with only some of them. The function

word should either serve the entire series or reappear in each item. Faulty sentences of this sort are common:

There is a feeling that the government is lagging, that business is looking ahead with enlightened self-interest, and labor is busy trying to sandbag against today's problems.

The illogical omission of *that* before the last serial item jars readers, whether or not they recognize what's wrong, and it might lead some to interpret the final clause as the second part of a compound sentence, balancing *There is a feeling*, rather than as the third in a series of subordinate clauses.

Since putting paired and serial elements in the same form helps identify them as compounds, using parallel structure for components that do not function together can be misleading. In one fairly common type of flawed sentence, readers have to choose a coordinate pair from a matched threesome in which two grammatically compatible elements precede *and* or *or* and one follows. Sometimes the conjunction follows both a verb in the main clause and a verb in a subordinate clause and precedes a verb that looks as if it could pair with either. The question is whether the third goes with the first or with the second. Chapter 2, on word order, includes a few examples of this problem. Here are two more:

The program became a successful model from which other programs developed and pioneered a variety of major innovations in management education.

We take pride in the work we do and appreciate your comments and suggestions on ways to serve you better.

In sentences like these, usually the simplest solution, though not necessarily the best, is to add a comma before the conjunction and a subject before the following verb (adding only a comma would separate the two verbs that belong together as well as the two that do not): . . . *work we do, and we appreciate.* . . . Sometimes, though, you can produce a better sentence by editing out the odd verb:

The program became a successful model for other programs and pioneered a variety of major innovations in management education.

We take pride in our work and appreciate your suggestions. . . .

If you can't easily eliminate the problem verb, you can take a different approach. Consider this sentence:

We discovered that our competitors had increased their market share and decided to introduce an improved product.

Here *decided* can pair with either *discovered* or *increased*—that is, its subject may be *we* or *competitors*. Assuming that the subject is *we*, you can clarify the sentence by repeating the pronoun before the second verb:

We discovered that our competitors had increased their market share, and we decided. . . .

Or you can eliminate the ambiguity about what *and* joins by eliminating *and*—in other words, by subordinating one of the verbs:

When we discovered that our competitors had increased their market share, we decided to. . . .

Of course, if the *decided* of the original version parallels *increased*, not *discovered*, you could make the connection clear by adding *had* before *decided*:

We discovered that our competitors had increased their market share and had decided to introduce an improved product.

The problem of misleading parallel structure is not restricted to verbs. The next sentence allows some confusion about which nouns function together:

The development of new electronics industries and the country's changing demographics will cushion the unemployment problem.

Some readers may see *industries* and *demographics* as objects of *of* before they recognize *development* and *demographics* as subjects of *will cushion*. Among the various ways of avoiding this possibility, certainly the easiest would be to reverse the order of the compound elements:

The country's changing demographics and the development of new electronics industries will cushion. . . .

Since no confusion arises when *and* links the terms adjacent to it, the transposition solves the problem. Whenever you have paired nouns like those in the preceding example, try to put the odd noun last. That is, make the noun followed by the prepositional phrase the second of the pair. Another possibility, as always, is to change the coordinate structure to a subordinate one:

Along with the country's changing demographics, the development of new electronics industries will. . . .

Or you could shift to a passive construction, if you could justify it, and put the parallel elements in matching *by* phrases:

The unemployment problem will be cushioned by the development of new electronics industries and by the country's changing demographics.

This approach wouldn't work, of course, if there were another *by* phrase to obscure the structure:

The unemployment problem will be cushioned by the new industries created by the electronics revolution and by the country's changing demographics.

In pairing phrases or clauses, as in pairing verbs or nouns, watch out for three of a kind. For example:

We understand that you plan to discontinue the incentive program that you adopted last fall and that the union has protested.

Is the third *that* clause the second one that modifies *program* or the second direct object of *understand*? Admittedly, you could avoid confusion by introducing the adjective clause, or clauses, with *which* instead of *that*, but not if you follow the advice of the usage critics who would restrict *which* to nonrestrictive clauses. You might better clarify by eliminating the odd *that* and leaving only the parallel pair. These two revisions correspond to the two possible meanings:

As we understand it, you plan to discontinue the incentive program that you adopted last year and that the union has protested.

We understand that the union has protested your plan to discontinue the incentive program that you adopted last year.

The next sentence has a confusing number of *of* phrases:

In the absence of any evidence of coercion of clients or of opposition to the proposal, I see no reason why we should not go ahead.

Are both evidence and opposition absent, or are both coercion and opposition unproved? If you start with *Since there is*, you can pin down the meaning by using *either . . . or* or *neither . . . nor* to mark the elements intended as coordinates:

Since there is no evidence either of coercion of clients or of opposition to the proposal, I see. . . .

Since there is neither opposition to the proposal nor evidence that clients were coerced, I see. . . .

Correlative conjunctions almost always provide a way of identifying parallel pairs where there is any ambiguity. Although you

shouldn't resort to this emphatic device frivolously, it can be useful if you find that you haven't clearly established what elements an *and* or *or* connects. Here's one more example, this one involving a trio of infinitives:

The dean said that she hoped to persuade the board to authorize the new curriculum and to increase the faculty in several disciplines.

Either the dean hoped to persuade and increase, or she hoped that the board would authorize and increase. Adding *both* after *hoped* or after *board* would eliminate the doubt.

In the preceding examples, where coordinate elements have the same form as some other element nearby, the parallel structure can mislead readers about what goes with what. Less commonly, parallel structure can mislead, not because it creates ambiguity about the matching parts but because it suggests a correspondence between elements that are too disparate to be associated. When Lewis Carroll groups cabbages and kings or Alexander Pope writes of husbands and lap dogs breathing their last, the effect is intentionally comic. Don't impose parallel structure on incongruities unless you're aiming at humor, because the result is likely to be ludicrous:

The police found no alcohol in his bloodstream but a loaded gun in his car.

Nylon tricot sleepwear will make her glamorous and still practical for traveling or lounging.

The proper management of parallel structure involves guiding readers smoothly through sentences by signaling the elements that work in pairs and series. There are, as Follett says, "a labyrinth of ways to go wrong." The following examples, both from printed sources, illustrate some of the ways not covered in the preceding discussion of specific flaws. Above all, these sentences show that putting parallel ideas in parallel form is essentially a matter of thinking straight, of recognizing how the various sentence components fit together. Elements that have the same relation to another element should have a family resemblance, and those that do not function together should not look as if they do.

Our first example contains two types of faulty parallelism—one relatively subtle, the other blatant:

Downsizing encompasses smaller cars, houses, and families, as well as conservation efforts; all of this affects iron and steel production, and rubber, lumber, glass, copper, and other basics.

The less obvious flaw lies in the first clause, where the serial items and the *as well as* phrase don't mesh. *Cars* and *houses* match well enough, but certainly *families* are not in the same category. The *as well as* phrase compounds the problem by bringing *conservation efforts* into the picture. When you stop to consider the logic of this grouping, you quickly realize that smaller cars and conservation efforts are not parallel notions. If nothing else, one is concrete, the other abstract. The writer has not thought through what the sentence should say, and judging from the quotation alone, you might have a hard time guessing. Here I happen to have inside information, so that I know what the author had in mind:

Downsizing encompasses smaller cars and houses, which in turn reflect conservation efforts and the trend toward smaller families. . . .

The last part of the sentence is also inexact: *production* does not belong in the same series with a list of basic materials. The second clause should read:

. . . all this affects the production of iron, steel, rubber, lumber, glass, copper, and other basic materials.

The final example in this section reflects the same sort of poor quality control that has cost American manufacturers business:

The Japanese machine cost \$60,000 less than the American model, was judged to be more flexible and have better controls, greater accuracy—and could be delivered faster.

You might begin attacking this sentence by making the verbs parallel. You can't convert the two passive verbs to active ones and still have a compound predicate, since they would require different subjects, but you could make the first verb passive to match the others. You might then put the cumbersome second serial element at the end, where it causes less trouble:

The Japanese machine was priced \$60,000 below the American model, could be delivered faster, and was judged to be more flexible and accurate and to have better controls.

Looking at this version, you might consider the parallel structure forced and try a different approach. What about that unwieldy ending? If *better controls* means only "controls permitting greater flexibility and accuracy," you could simplify:

Not only was the Japanese machine judged more flexible and accurate than the American model, but it was priced \$60,000 lower and could be delivered faster.

But if *better controls* is not implicit in this version, what precisely does the phrase mean? A more specific statement might also be more graceful:

. . . judged easier to operate and more flexible. . .

OTHER INCOMPATIBLES

In addition to checking pairs and series for parallel structure, pay attention to the elements you compare and contrast. These too should be parallel in form, though disparate wording is probably the most innocuous of the ways that comparisons can go wrong. There's nothing seriously amiss with this sentence:

In the early stages of market declines, the risk of making less money is more palatable than the risk of substantial losses.

Nevertheless, wouldn't anyone with half an ear compare *the risk of substantial losses* with *the risk of reduced returns* rather than with *the risk of making less money*? More often, a faulty comparison involves elements compatible in form but incompatible in substance. Both may be nouns, for example, but nouns denoting entirely different sorts of things. Not all the precepts of grammar seem logical, but the rule that you can only compare like things is patently sensible. Though no one would say that *five is better than blue* or that *eating is better than Sunday*, comparisons just as witless often find their way into print, not because the authors are simple-minded but because they don't write what they mean. For instance:

The newspaper has been around since 1870, but its editorial style is as aggressive as a publication started yesterday.

Clearly the author means to say that the style of the paper is as aggressive as that of a newspaper started yesterday, but the stated comparison is between a style and a publication. It doesn't mislead us, because we know better than to believe what it says, but the wording is sloppy. We all make slips in talking, and if anyone calls us on them, we're likely to say, "Oh, you know what I mean." But in writing, where presumably we have a chance to look over what we've set down, there's less excuse for imprecision.

The last example illustrates a common sort of inexact comparison, and you can usually correct it simply by adding *that of* or *those of* to provide a fitting balance for the left-hand side of the comparison. Here are two more examples, with the corrections in brackets:

Salary levels for bank portfolio managers are at least a third less than [those for] investment managers in brokerage houses.

The cost of renovating the offices was estimated to be considerably below [that of] leasing new space.

It's even simpler to straighten out faulty comparisons in this form:

New York's taxes are higher than most other states.

Here *taxes* is compared with *states*, but you need only add an apostrophe after *states* to make the statement logical, since *taxes* would be implicit after the possessive. Of course, you use *that of* or a possessive form, not both. The *that of* is redundant in this example:

Butte's downfall may be similar to that of Detroit's.

In this sort of sentence the apostrophe works better than a *that of* construction. A demonstrative that refers to a noun preceded by an adjective seems to stand for the combination—here for *Butte's downfall*, not just *downfall*. Similarly, the sentence *Sales taxes are worse than those imposed by the IRS* is inexact, because *those* points to *sales taxes*, not just *taxes*.

A comparison is open to misinterpretation if it fails to indicate whether the word that follows *than* or *as* contrasts with the subject or the object of the preceding clause. You can usually clarify the meaning by adding a verb, or a subject and verb, to the second part of the comparison. For example:

Japanese workers fear automation less than their American counterparts [do].

The mayor considers the vigilantes more threatening than [she does] the criminals.

Sometimes you only need a preposition to show how the right-hand element fits into the sentence. This one-word addition provides an elliptical clause, enabling readers to understand an implicit subject and verb. For example:

The book deals more with the wonders of high technology than [with] the implications for labor.

Our earnings last year were slightly higher than [in] 1979.

We imported more oil from Saudi Arabia than [from] Mexico.

While imprecisely stated comparisons are usually more slovenly than confusing, some are genuinely unclear. Left uncorrected, the last ex-

ample, for instance, could mean either that Saudi Arabia supplied more oil than Mexico did or that we imported more oil than Mexico did. Similarly, the earlier comparison involving vigilantes and criminals could mean either that the mayor finds the vigilantes more threatening than she does criminals or that she finds them more threatening than criminals do. This sort of ambiguity, though easily clarified, is a common fault, so watch for it in your own writing. You should, in fact, look critically at all your comparisons to make sure that they make sense.

If a comparison is too muddled to salvage by inserting a word or two, you may have to scrap it and start over. Certainly that's what the author of this sentence should have done:

The tract influenced Mill, and he claimed to have reached a state of mind differing less from that of the sect than existed previously.

Elliptical constructions work when readers automatically infer the missing words from those already stated. But in this example what words are they to understand between *than* and *existed*? What existed previously? The only possibility the sentence provides is *a state of mind*, but repeating that phrase doesn't solve the problem:

... he claimed to have reached a state of mind differing less from that of the sect than the state of mind that existed previously.

Readers need to add something more on their own to keep *state of mind* from seeming parallel to *that of the sect* instead of to the earlier *state of mind*:

... he claimed to have reached a state of mind differing less from that of the sect than his previous state of mind had differed from the sect's.

Obviously, readers aren't going to work that hard to do what the author should have done for them. Besides, though the reconstructed sentence verges on clarity, it's stunningly awkward.

Most writers are capable of drafting such poor sentences, but they should also be capable of recognizing and rectifying their errors when they revise. Before you can recast a badly tangled comparison, you have to figure out exactly what terms you intend to contrast. It takes time and concentration to rework the example we have been discussing:

The tract influenced Mill, and he claimed that his state of mind now differed less from the sect's than it had before.

Of course, as the author, you might decide to jettison *state of mind* as more trouble than it's worth:

... he claimed that he now differed less from the sect than he had before.

Let's look at one more example:

The report on credit explains why lending institutions may regard ownership of an old car more favorably than a new one.

The sentence illogically compares *ownership* and *new one*, but you can't correct it by simply adding *that of* after *than*. That remedy only serves when the *of* phrase shows possession, and you have a different situation here. Although you can say *the hood of the car* or *the car's hood*, you can't say *the ownership of a car* or *a car's ownership*; ownership does not belong to a car.

When you start working on the sentence, you might decide to restate the comparison so that it involves the two terms that naturally contrast with each other, *an old car* and *a new one*. Using some form of the verb *own* instead of the unwieldy noun *ownership* would give you more flexibility in rewording. The revision would have to fit the context, of course, but here are two possibilities:

The report explains why owning an old car rather than a new one may be in your favor when you apply for credit.

The report explains why lending institutions may consider you a better credit risk if you own an old car than if you own a new one.

Just as the elements you compare should be in the same category, so should any elements that you group together. Not all related items are linked by coordinating conjunctions. Phrases introduced by words like *along with*, *together with*, *similar to*, *like*, and *unlike* should have objects of the same sort as the words the phrases modify. Chapter 2 discusses the importance of placing such phrases so that they seem to modify the appropriate words. It is even more important to include the appropriate words. In the following sentence, for example, the *among* phrase has no anchor, no word grammatically compatible with its object:

Federal reserve banks distribute currency, transfer funds, and pay government bills, among other responsibilities.

You can correctly say that *distributing currency* is among the banks' responsibilities but not that *distribute currency* is among their responsi-

bilities. Here are a few more sentences, along with revisions, to illustrate the problem:

Unlike taking care of other pets, fish are hardly any trouble.

- Fish, unlike other pets, are hardly any trouble to care for.

Along with his other faults, he never met deadlines, so we had to discharge him.

- His failure to meet deadlines, along with his other faults, forced us to discharge him.

When we go out to lunch, she always plays the fool, like asking for chopsticks in an Italian restaurant.

- When we go out to lunch, she always does something silly, like asking for chopsticks in an Italian restaurant.

It is possible, at least theoretically, to overindulge in parallelism. An addiction to elaborately balanced clauses could result in an artificial, mannered style. But few writers today sin in that direction. You are not likely to go wrong if you concentrate on putting comparable sentence components in parallel form. Although accomplished writers can sometimes justify setting the rules aside, guard against careless violations by routinely checking for them:

1. Look at the items you present in series to see that they match in grammatical form, that you haven't intermingled nouns with verbs or adjectives, infinitives with gerunds, or phrases with clauses. Make sure, too, that you have been consistent about repeating initial prepositions, conjunctions, possessive pronouns, or articles; you usually have to include such words with all serial items or with only the first. If you can't put all the items in the same form, consider recasting the sentence to eliminate the series; the grouping may be illogical.
2. Notice the elements connected by *and* and *or* and make sure that they are grammatically equivalent. Then ask yourself whether readers will immediately recognize what terms the conjunctions link. If the sentence components that look like a pair are not the ones you intend, revise to preclude misreading. Pay particular attention to the words that follow correlative conjunctions and make sure that they match exactly. If you cannot put coordinate elements in the same form without sounding unnatural, consider uncoupling them; they may be incompatible.

3. Finally, look closely at the elements you compare, especially those that follow *as* or *than*, to see that they are logically and grammatically similar, that you are comparing like with like. Also make sure to group like with like; check prepositional phrases that begin with words like *along with*, *together with*, and *among* to see that their objects belong in the same category as the words the phrases modify.

If you review your writing in these ways, you should detect any errors in parallel structure you've let slip by. Checking for mismatches becomes automatic after a while, and eliminating them will go a long way toward improving both the fluency and the clarity of your writing.